FLAGSHIP SOLUTION SCALING TRACK PROFILE

Scaling the Integration of Micro and Small Enterprises and Smallholder Farmers into School Meals Programs in Kenya

Scaling for Impact Science Program | Area of Work 2

Grand Challenge 3 · Drive Demand, Shape Behavior & Activate Policy for Nutrition

Flagship 3.1 · Catalyzing Demand for Nutritious Diets through Markets, Institutions & Policy

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Foreword

CGIAR SCALING FOR IMPACT · AREA OF WORK 2 — PATHWAYS TO SCALE IN AGRIFOOD SYSTEMS

CGIAR produces far more scale-ready innovation than currently reaches farmers at scale. Closing that gap is the purpose of the CGIAR Scaling for Impact (S4I) Science Program. Within S4I, Area of Work 2 — Pathways to Scale in Agrifood Systems — is organized around three Grand Challenges that mark where scaling can unlock the largest development returns across food, land, and water systems in a climate crisis. These Grand Challenges were defined through an evidence-led process — drawing on the CGIAR Impact Report 2022–2024, Initiative reporting, and an analysis of eleven major donor strategies — so that each rests on demonstrated scaling potential and connects directly to the priorities of CGIAR's funders.

Under each Grand Challenge sits a focused set of **Scaling Flagships** that "dock with" and support CGIAR's Science Programs — taking mature innovation bundles and accelerating their delivery and scaling systems:

- **Grand Challenge 1 — Close the Climate Adaptation Gap** through scalable climate services and smart water management

    Flagship 1.1 — Digital Climate Services for Resilient Farm & Enterprise Management

    Flagship 1.2 — Scaling Smart Irrigation & Climate-Resilient Water Systems

- **Grand Challenge 2 — Deliver Inputs and Services at Scale** through inclusive market systems

    Flagship 2.1 — Scaling Resilient, Nutritious & Biodiverse Seed & Soil Systems

    Flagship 2.2 — Entrepreneurship through Mechanization & Postharvest Services

    Flagship 2.3 — Genetics, Inputs & Services for Animals & Aquaculture

- **Grand Challenge 3 — Drive Demand, Shape Behavior & Activate Policy** for nutrition

    Flagship 3.1 — Catalyzing Demand for Nutritious Diets through Markets, Institutions & Policy

Each Flagship is delivered through **Scaling Solution Tracks** — the profile that follows is one of them. Tracks are run deliberately as large, time-bound scaling campaigns, not as research projects or pilots. Experience across the portfolio shows that the binding constraint to scaling is rarely the innovation itself; it is *system integration* — the delivery and business models, finance and risk-sharing, institutional and policy alignment, and coordination among actors required to move a proven solution into widespread use. Each track therefore bundles a validated innovation with a clear delivery pathway, committed partners, and a defined geography, and is driven through and with scaling partners rather than by CGIAR alone — leveraging complementary investments to amplify reach.

This campaign approach lets S4I concentrate resources, operate in performance-based mode against measurable KPIs — farmers adopting innovations, jobs created, consumers gaining access to healthier diets, and scaling finance and supportive policy mobilized — and hold itself accountable to the S4I 2030 outcome targets and CGIAR's Impact Area goals. Across every track, scaling is pursued responsibly and inclusively, with women, youth, and marginalized groups systematically included by design.

1. Overview

Kenya's national school meals program (SMP) has a bold ambition to scale from reaching 24% of primary school children to 10 million learners. However, this expansion faces a critical bottleneck: the current centralized model struggles to operate effectively in underserved, poor urban areas like Nairobi's informal settlements. In these contexts, schools, often informal private institutions, lack formal links to food suppliers, and local micro and small enterprises (MSEs) and smallholder farmers (SHFs) are excluded from the school's food value chain. This exclusion represents a missed opportunity, as these local producers are a primary source of food and jobs in these communities.

This Scaling Track aims to solve this problem by developing and scaling a "lean model" that integrates MSEs and SHFs into the SMP food system within these marginalized urban contexts. The goal is to optimize local food sourcing for school meals, ensuring safe and nutritious foods for children while simultaneously supporting local economies and creating jobs through gender-inclusive approaches. The core solution is a bundled innovation that combines (1) demand creation in communities to highlight the importance of school meals and nutrition, and (2) new procurement processes that formally link organized MSEs and SHFs with schools. This approach builds directly on a successful 2024-2025 pilot implemented by the African Population and Health Research Center (APHRC) in three Nairobi settlements, which demonstrated clear gains in market integration for local producers. With catalytic funding from S4I, the IFPRI-led team will partner with APHRC and Wasafiri to adapt this pilot into a scalable, cost-effective model and expand it to reach thousands more students, producers, and community members.

2. Innovation Bundle and Scaling Ambition

2.1 What is Being Scaled

- **Lean Procurement Model:** A streamlined, cost-effective process for developing food supply links between schools and local MSEs/SHFs, organized through Local Business Associations (LBAs).
- **Demand Creation Toolkit:** A set of community-based engagement methods (e.g., participatory cooking demonstrations, radio messaging, school-level outreach) via Community Organized Groups designed to increase awareness of the importance of education, school meals, and healthy and sustainable diets.
- **LBA Capacity-Building Package:** A training and support program for MSEs and SHFs on food safety standards, business operations, and how to navigate school procurement requirements.

2.2 Evidence of Impact

- **Economic Multiplier:** Every USD 1 invested in Kenya's homegrown SMP generates a **USD 2.26 income multiplier** (Alderman et al., 2025; Gupta et al., 2025).
- **Pilot Success (APHRC, 2025):** The pilot demonstrated that the approach leads to tangible gains for MSEs and SHFs in terms of market integration, organization into business associations, and direct engagement with consumers and schools.
- **Government Priority:** The approach directly supports Kenya's Action Plan for Scaling Up School Meals Programme (2024–2030), which identifies local procurement as a key pillar for expansion.

2.3 Scaling Targets

Outcome Metric	2026 Target	Long-term Goal (3–5 years)
MSEs/SHFs trained, organized, and ready for food provision	188	1,000+
Individuals reached by demand creation activities (schoolchildren, parents, community members)	6,938	600,000+
Jobs created or improved	1,500	Not specified
School communities engaged	24 schools across 3 informal settlements in Nairobi	120+ school communities across Nairobi and Kisumu
Students provided with diverse locally produced foods	Not a 2026 target	24,000

3. Scaling Pathway and Theory of Change

3.1 Pathway Strategy The scaling pathway is designed to transition a successful, intensive pilot into a "lean" model suitable for government-supported expansion. The core strategy is a **public-private-community partnership model** focused on system integration. The pathway involves three key elements:

- **Adaptation and Simplification:** The first step is a multi-stakeholder workshop to distill the pilot's complex methods into a core, cost-effective "lean model" that can be scaled to new areas.
- **Building Supply and Demand in Parallel:** Simultaneously, the track will (a) activate and build the capacity of MSEs/SHFs by organizing them into LBAs and connecting them to schools, and (b) generate community demand for school meals through targeted outreach, ensuring a sustainable market for the newly linked suppliers.
- **Policy Embedding:** Throughout the process, the team will work closely with the Kenya School Meals Coalition and county governments to address regulatory bottlenecks (e.g., food safety certification, procurement rules) and embed the new model into the national SMP framework.

3.2 Theory of Change If underserved urban schools are linked to formally organized MSEs and SHFs through a simplified, locally-adapted procurement model, **and if** communities are actively engaged to create demand for school meals and understand their nutritional value, **then** MSEs and SHFs will gain a reliable market, leading to improved incomes and job creation. This will result in **increased availability of safe, nutritious, and locally-sourced food in schools**, which in turn will drive improved diets, school attendance and learning outcomes for children, ultimately contributing to a more inclusive, healthy, and sustainable national school meals system.

3.3 Key Activities Funded by S4I

- **Scaling Design and Adaptation:** A multi-stakeholder workshop to review pilot lessons, adapt methods and tools, and co-create the "lean" scaling plan for new areas.

- **Demand Creation:** Implementation of community outreach through existing community groups (COGs) and school-level engagement activities, including community radio broadcasts and participatory gardening and cooking demonstrations.
- **MSE/SHF Activation and Capacity Building:** Mapping of the local food supply chain, training MSEs and SHFs in food safety and business operations and strengthening Local Business Associations (LBAs) to act as formal suppliers. Facilitation of "deal rooms" to connect LBAs with private sector actors for long-term sustainability.
- **Evidence and Learning:** Systematic monitoring of the scaling process and outcomes to document lessons, identify bottlenecks, and inform further adaptations and policy dialogues.

4. Partners and Roles

Partner Type	Specific Partners and Quantities	Role in Scaling Pathway
Demand Partners	**Government of Kenya** (Ministries of Education, Agriculture, Health), **Nairobi County**, **NACONEK**, **Kenya School Meals Coalition**, MSE Cooperatives, Schools.	Define the scaling ambition; provide the policy framework and ultimate institutional home for the scaled model; express demand for solutions to reach marginalized populations.
Scaling Partners	**African Population and Health Research Center (APHRC)** (Lead implementing partner), **Wasafiri** (Implementation partner for MSE/SHF engagement), **Novo Nordisk Foundation Project** (IFPRI/KEMRI), **Food4Education**, **HarvestPlus** (via AoW 3).	**APHRC/Wasafiri** execute the on-the-ground scaling activities, from community mobilization to LBA training. **Other partners** provide complementary expertise (e.g., data systems, menu quality, bean integration) and channels for wider system influence and learning.

Funding Model: S4I catalytic funding supports the adaptation, partnership coordination, evidence generation, and direct implementation costs for scaling the model in new areas, while the core cost of the food itself is borne by schools, parents, government capitation grants, and other development partners.

5. Enabling Environment and Risks

5.1 Opportunities

- **Strong Government Commitment:** Kenya has an ambitious, costed national plan to scale its SMP to 10 million children, with local procurement as a stated priority.
- **Active Multi-Stakeholder Platforms:** The Kenya School Meals Coalition provides a ready-made forum for policy dialogue, coordination, and embedding lessons from this track into national policy.

- **Momentum from Major Investments:** Large initiatives like the Novo Nordisk Foundation project are strengthening the national SMP's data and monitoring systems, creating an entry point for integrating and sustaining this track's innovations.
- **Proven Local Partners:** APHRC is a highly respected policy research institution in Kenya with deep connections to government, ensuring credibility and a pathway for evidence uptake.

5.2 Challenges and Mitigation

- **Complex Procurement and Food Safety Regulations:** The bureaucratic maze for becoming an approved school food supplier is a major barrier for small, informal MSEs.
- *Mitigation:* Policy engagement is a core component of the track. APHRC and the team will work directly with the School Meals Coalition and county governments to simplify and clarify these regulations and provide direct support to LBAs to achieve compliance.
- **Financial Sustainability of School Meals:** Government budgets are constrained, with most education funds allocated to teacher salaries.
- *Mitigation:* The track focuses on the efficiency and effectiveness of the *procurement* side, not on financing the meals themselves. By developing a more cost-effective model for local sourcing, it aims to make the program more sustainable for the government and other funders.
- **Operational Capacity of MSEs/SHFs:** Small producers may struggle with the need for consistent supply, bulk quantities, and reliable quality.
- *Mitigation:* The track's capacity-building package, delivered through LBAs, is designed to address these issues through training on aggregation, seasonal planning, and quality control.
- **Fragmented SMP Landscape:** The existence of many different models (INGO-led, government, private) could lead to duplication and confusion.
- *Mitigation:* The track is actively working to link with other initiatives (e.g., HarvestPlus, Food4Education, Novo Nordisk project) through the School Meals Coalition to ensure cross-learning and complementarity rather than competition.

6. Learning and Adaptation

6.1 Monitoring Focus

- **Process Outcomes:** Effectiveness of the "lean model" adaptation; fidelity of implementation; cost-effectiveness of the new approach compared to the pilot.
- **Behavior Change:** Shifts in community awareness and demand for school meals; adoption of new practices by MSEs and SHFs.
- **System Outcomes:** Changes in local food availability; evidence of policy or regulatory modifications at the county or national level; sustainability and market integration of LBAs beyond the project period.

6.2 Adaptive Management Learning will be embedded in the track's DNA. The team will hold quarterly check-ins with the S4I Area of Work 2 team to review monitoring data and discuss progress. Key insights will be shared and discussed during regular meetings of the Kenya School Meals Coalition, allowing for real-time feedback into the policy process. The mid-year review will be a formal opportunity to assess what is working, identify necessary pivots, and adjust the implementation plan for the following year.

7. Next Steps and Timeline (2026)

Q1 (Jan-Mar)	• **Scaling Design and Planning Workshop** (Feb) with all key partners to finalize the "lean model" and 2026 implementation plan. • Finalize agreements and obtain necessary permits and ethical approvals for work in Nairobi's informal settlements. • Begin profiling of food supply chain infrastructure in new areas of Nairobi.
Q2 (Apr-Jun)	• Initiate demand creation activities through Community Organized Groups (COGs) aligned with School Term 2. • Begin activation and capacity building of new MSEs and SHFs through Local Business Associations (LBAs). • Ongoing policy engagement with Nairobi County and the School Meals Coalition.
Q3 (Jul-Sep)	• Continue LBA training and support, including organizing "deal rooms" with private sector actors. • Continue community-level demand creation activities. • Begin systematic monitoring of scaling process and early outcomes.
Q4 (Oct-Dec)	• Review Year 1 implementation data and lessons learned. • Share preliminary findings with partners and at School Meals Coalition meetings. • Begin planning for Year 2 expansion to Kisumu County.

Communications and Knowledge: Key knowledge products will include a publicly available "lean model" toolkit, policy briefs targeting county and national governments, and regular updates shared through the CGIAR and partner networks. Major milestones, such as the signing of new supply agreements between LBAs and schools, will be highlighted.

8. Contact

- **Sunny S. Kim (IFPRI-DC)** | sunny.kim@cgiar.org
- **Naureen Karachiwalla (IFPRI-Kenya)** | n.karachiwalla@cgiar.org